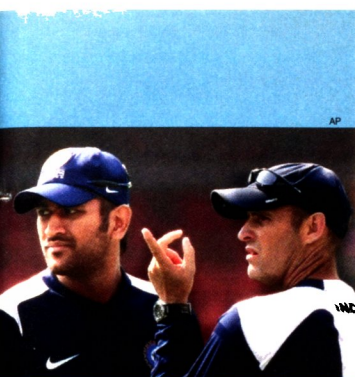




“It’s always better to start as underdogs. There’s no point in taking undue pressure.”

M.S. DHONI, Captain, Indian team



| By Sharda Ugra |

A quick check of current New Zealand cricket facts: Its captain looks like Harry Potter. Its hottest young batsman was christened Luteru Ross Poutoa Lote and its wicketkeeper answers to ‘Baz’. Another fella called Jesse Ryder could just bring the double chin into fashion. Everyone else is just tall and apart from English, the natives speak a strange tongue called Rugby.

It is cold there. It is windy. It is quiet. Yet this is the place where India, on a hot, noisy streak, must go and play the kind of cricket that they have not been able to for the past four decades. Or actually, where they must play the cricket they have since the horror movie of the 2007 World Cup came to a grisly close.

Today, with a team that has uncharacteristically begun to blend consistency and domination, India stand at the foot of a steeply-climbing slope at the end of which lies a place where they have never been. Or as Bono sang, “A place that has to be believed to be seen”—the summit of world cricket, number one in all forms of the game. But before they can begin to dream big, India must travel to these islands to launch their audacious odyssey.

New Zealand has become India’s unlikely final frontier. It remains the only country where India have not won a Test in this current millennium that has marked a Beamon-esque leap in India’s overseas cricket. Sourav Ganguly, under whose captaincy it all started, is watching closely. “India’s test will start now; the next two seasons will decide where they will go as a team,” he says and adds, “I have hope and a lot of faith.” New Zealand are ranked eighth (out of 9) in Tests and behind India at number four in the ODIs. This tour is probably the first time in recent memory that India are headed for a tour to a major Test nation and are actually expected to win.

It is almost as if New Zealand has become a series India cannot lose. Captain M.S. Dhoni tries to crank down the excitement. “It’s always better to start as underdogs. There’s no point in

taking undue pressure. We’re looking to play good cricket and hopefully come back with a couple of trophies.”

A trophy of any kind would be monumental. After registering its first-ever overseas series victory (*see box*) in the land the Maoris call Aetearoa, India have not won a Test match since 1976, 33 years and five tours. However, in January 2007, an India under-19 team provided some variation on a sorry theme, winning a youth one-day series 2-1 and drawing the youth tests 1-1. In that squad were Ishant Sharma who now fronts the Indian attack and rookie Dhawal Kulkarni. Sharma forms one half of what former India fast bowler Javagal Srinath calls, “the best new ball pair in the world”. His senior partner, Zaheer Khan, is laughing at the consternation over reverse swing and cross seam and subcontinental conditions and bowling into the wind or with it. “All I need is swing—conventional, reverse... anything.”

Srinath rates this Indian attack as “better than those that had toured before and better than the hosts’ collective experience”. Bowling coach Venkatesh Prasad is confident that his bowlers will adjust quickly, saying that in the past 18 months they have switched countries (Bangladesh to Ireland and England to South Africa to India to Sri Lanka). “We have confidence and momentum,” Prasad says.

Watching from a cattle farm near Christchurch is the team’s former coach John Wright who believes India is now one of the more balanced sides in the world. “They have most bases and all conditions covered,” he says. Virender Sehwag believes New Zealand will have to “think twice” before preparing the kind of wickets they “dished out the last time”. Who can forget the last time? In 2002-2003, when India lost both Tests with a top total of 162 in four innings, and won two ODIs in seven. In one Test, the team scoring 99 actually took a first innings lead and opener Sanjay Bangar had completed both his innings by stumps on Day One.

Wasn’t that was New Zealand was really like? All green and gorgeous on